

Are LLMs a Force for Good?

Principles vs Practice - A Notre Dame Case Study

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Abstract

Large Language Models (LLMs) such as ChatGPT are reshaping academic life at Notre Dame. This study examined how undergraduate and graduate students of the Notre Dame tri-campus community perceive LLMs in relation to institutional mission, ethical use, and academic integrity. A mixed-methods survey (n=69) captured beliefs, self-reported behaviors, and open-ended reflections. Results reveal a striking gap between principle and practice. 90% believe LLMs can be used ethically per Catholic mission, yet 45% admit school misuse and 22% personal misuse. Students also rate their understanding of professors' AI policies (3.9/5) significantly higher than professors' understanding of student use (3.0/5). These findings underscore tensions between institutional principles and student practice in the AI era.

Link to code/dataset/survey questions:
https://github.com/JonathanKarr33/llms_force_for_good

1. Introduction

Large Language Models (LLMs) have entered academic life and are here to stay. At Catholic institutions such as the University of Notre Dame, questions of ethical use intersect with mission: promoting human dignity, flourishing communities, and pursuit of truth. Prior work has explored AI in education [1], [2] and academic integrity [3], but investigations at faith-based universities remain limited. This study explores how Notre Dame tri-campus students reconcile principles of ethical LLM use with their reported behaviors and perceptions of faculty understanding. We ask: (1) Are LLMs a force for good? (2) Does the use of LLMs align with your religious values?

2. Methods

2.1 Survey Design

A Google Form survey measured LLM usage frequency, purposes, ethical beliefs, and self-reported misuse (school and personal). Items included 1–5 scales for “force for good,” Catholic Social Teaching (CST) importance, faith importance, alignment with university

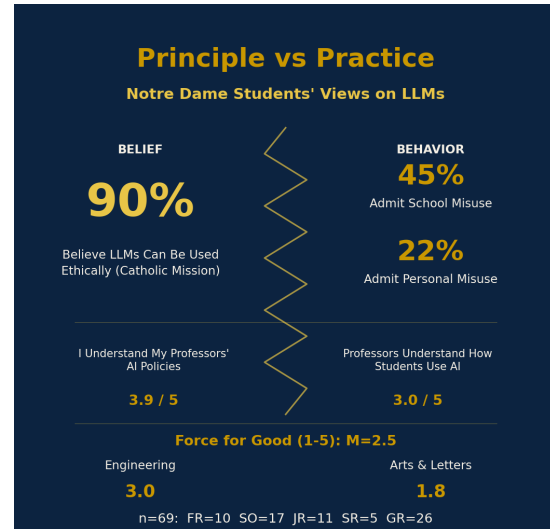


Figure 1: Principle vs Practice Main Figure

values, and understanding of AI policies. We chose 5-point scales for optimal reliability and validity while remaining practical for respondents [4]. We defined ‘force for good’ according to Notre Dame’s mission of promoting human dignity, creating flourishing communities, and pursuing knowledge and truth, and we used Conwill et al.’s definitions of CST [5]. We also included questions on how, why, and when students use LLMs. Finally, we included open-ended prompts on ways LLMs are or are not a force for good. Demographics (university, grade, gender, college) were recorded.

2.2 Participants

A total of 69 students completed the survey. Demographics: 10 Freshmen, 17 Sophomores, 11 Juniors, 5 Seniors, 26 Graduate Students. Gender: 42 Female, 27 Male. Colleges: College of Engineering (27), College of Arts & Letters (23), College of Science (11), Mendoza College of Business (5), Notre Dame Law School (5), School of Architecture (2), Keough School of Global Affairs (2), Saint Mary’s College (1), Holy Cross College (1). Note, some are dual majors.

2.3 Analysis

Descriptive statistics summarized beliefs, behaviors, and understanding. Bonferroni correction [6] addressed multiple comparisons. Paired *t*-tests [7] evaluated the

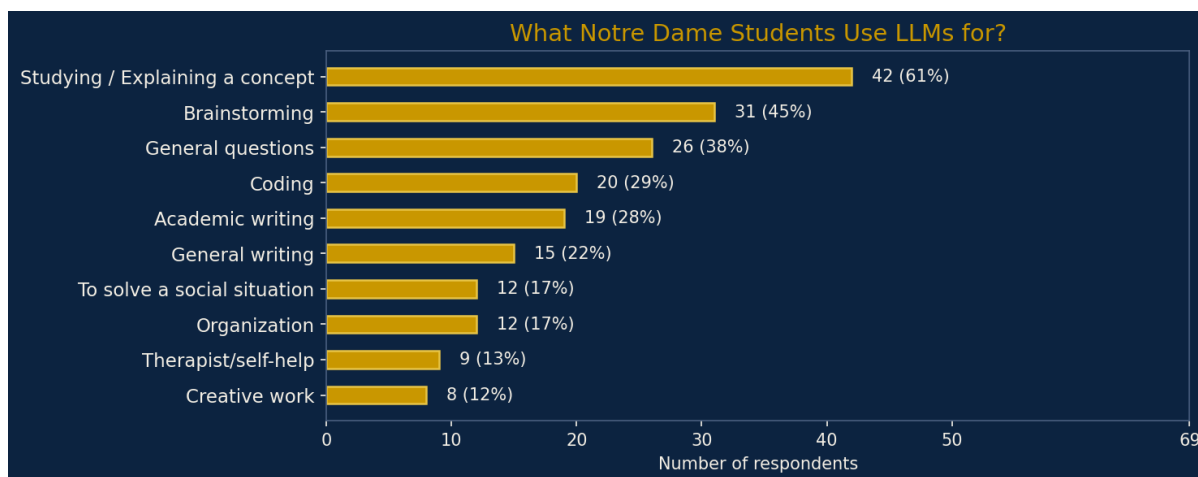


Figure 2: How Notre Dame Students Use LLMs (>10%).

understanding gap. Kruskal-Wallis [8] and chi-square [9] tests explored differences by grade, college, and gender. Thematic analysis identified themes in open-ended responses.

3. Results

3.1 Quantitative Findings

90% of students agreed LLMs can be used ethically per Catholic mission; 45% admitted school misuse, and 22% personal misuse. Students rated their understanding of professors' AI policies at 3.9/5 vs. 3.0/5 for professors' understanding of student use, a significant gap ($t = 5.89, p < 0.001$). Bonferroni-corrected correlations ($\alpha = 0.008$) showed no relationship between force for good ratings and CST or faith importance. At the end of the survey, when we asked participants if AI was a force for good, the median was 2.5. Engineering was the highest (3.0) while Arts & Letters was the lowest (1.8). Remarkably, 23% used LLMs for therapist/self-help or to solve a social situation (5 used both). Finally, daily users reported 59% school misuse vs. 32% weekly-or-less ($p = 0.05$).

3.2 Qualitative Responses

We selected two positive and two negative qualitative responses on how participants perceive LLMs as a force for good or not.

How LLMs are a Force For Good:

1. 'It is an equalizer. Like Internet, if used correctly can uplift a lot of people, improve conditions and help people.'

2. 'They can spark creativity, and help explain difficult concepts'

How LLMs are Not a Force For Good:

1. 'Humans are becoming increasingly reliant upon technology and no longer able to think for themselves.'

They no longer have the patience to struggle through problems that don't have immediate solutions.'

2. 'It harms the environment, takes away jobs, and overall dumbs people down because they don't think'

4. Discussion

Findings reveal a clear gap between belief and behavior. While most students endorse ethical LLM use in principle, nearly half admit school misuse, suggesting that moral conviction alone does not translate into consistent practice. Adding to this tension, students perceive a disconnect between how professors understand AI use and how it actually unfolds in student life.

Alignment with university values proved a stronger 'force for good' perception than either Catholic Social Teaching or personal faith, a finding that invites deeper reflection on how institutional identity shapes ethical reasoning. Perhaps most concerning is that 23% of students turn to LLMs for therapeutic support or guidance in social situations (7% overlap). This impulse risks misplacing trust: virtue is cultivated in persons, not in algorithms, and the irreplaceable roles of spiritual directors and human counselors cannot be delegated to tools [10]. Ultimately, LLMs may inform our decisions, but they shall not make them.

Limitations include self-selection bias, self-report of sensitive behaviors, small cell sizes for some subgroups, and generalizability to non-Catholic institutions.

5. Conclusion

At Notre Dame, students largely believe LLMs can be used ethically in line with the Catholic mission, but reported behaviors and perception gaps suggest institutional principles have not fully translated into practice. Strengthening policy clarity, faculty-student dialogue, and mission-aligned guidance may help narrow the principle-practice divide.

Ethics

This study was reviewed and approved by the University of Notre Dame Institutional Review Board (IRB Protocol #25-12-9770). All participants provided informed consent.

Acknowledgments

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